These developments helped prompt the new Chinese government to mount a military invasion on Tibet immediately after taking over power in China. Mao initially gave this responsibility to General (later Marshal) Peng Dehuai, who was in charge of north-west China, but General Peng demurred due to difficult climatic conditions and terrain (the Xinjiang-Tibet highway through Aksai Chin had not yet been built). The liberation of Tibet was eventually entrusted to Deng Xiaoping who headed the south-western Bureau. [1] Within a month of Mao's proclamation establishing the People's Republic of China, from the Tiananmen Rostrum on 1 October 1949, the Soviet Ambassador in Beijing, N.V. Roshchin, recorded in his diary that Premier Zhou Enlai had informed him about Chinese plans to attack Tibet immediately after the liberation of Sichuan and Xinjiang. [2] The Chinese objective was clear and simple, but the task was complex. For one, the Chinese were not physically present inside Tibet, which had, for all practical purposes, been autonomous since the fall of the Qing Empire in 1911. The Chinese liaison mission had also been expelled by the Tibetans in July 1949. Secondly, the Communists also faced formidable logistics issues in getting troops and supplies into Tibet. Thirdly, the Americans were openly hostile towards the new Chinese regime.

The Communist leadership felt the Americans may exploit Tibet's desire for independence. In this context they considered it possible that India, which they deemed to be a 'capitalist' country, might facilitate American assistance of Tibetan independence if they delayed the takeover of Tibet. Mao himself did not have a positive attitude towards Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru or India. In his letter to the Communist Party of India General Secretary, B.T. Ranadive, on 19 November 1949, he called Nehru an 'imperialist collaborator'. [3] Distrust of Indian intentions was thus a factor in the decision to invade Tibet.